

Proposal to Provide Professional Services to
US Highway 169 Corridor Coalition

July 18, 2013

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Proprietary and
Confidential
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BACKGROUND

The U.S. Highway 169 Corridor Coalition formed in 2009 to advocate for transportation needs along the 169 corridor. Lead by an Executive Committee and operated with the assistance of the Technical Committee, the 169 Corridor Coalition released a Request for Proposals (RFP) seeking a qualified vendor to perform Communications/Technology and Administrative support services.

ABOUT CONNOLLY KUHL GROUP

The Connolly Kuhl Group operates under the simple premise of advocating on behalf of their clients while navigating through the public affairs arena.

As a full service public affairs firm, the Connolly Kuhl Group (CKG) is committed to bringing their clients exceptional service through strategic planning, grassroots marketing and mobilization, government relations, coalition building and media/communications relations. With more than 25 years of combined experience and proven track record of success, CKG has mastered the ability of understand, maneuver and influence government as well as public opinion and private entities.

The Connolly Kuhl Group is active statewide in the business community. They currently serve as members of the Dakota County Regional Chamber of Commerce, Minneapolis Regional Chamber of Commerce, River Heights Chamber of Commerce, Rochester Area Chamber of Commerce, St. Cloud Area Chamber of Commerce, St. Paul Area Chamber of Commerce and Minnesota Chamber of Commerce.

TEAM

Patrick Connolly

Patrick Connolly, co-founder and principal of the Connolly Kuhl Group, has more than 15 years of experience in grassroots marketing and mobilization, public policy and communications strategies.

Connolly's successful grassroots experience includes public policy and community relations efforts for the Rochester Coalition and Southeast Minnesota Rail Alliance. He's also led and supported coalition efforts on behalf of the Hennepin County Sheriff Foundation, the Republican Party of Minnesota and Alliance for a Healthier Minnesota.

Prior to working at CKG, Connolly developed and coordinated targeted and results-oriented grassroots campaigns and outreach events as well as multi-city tours and meetings for his clients. With unabashed zeal, Connolly has garnered coverage for his clients in print, broadcast, radio and digital media outlets. Connolly earned his political stripes in the 2002 Coleman for U.S. Senate campaign as a lead member of the grassroots field team. After Coleman's historic victory, Connolly transitioned his mobilization skills to the U.S. Senate office as a policy liaison for Senator Coleman.

Carl Kuhl

Carl Kuhl, co-founder and principal of the Connolly Kuhl Group, has more than a decade of experience in politics and public policy. Kuhl has served in numerous senior communications roles for a United States Senator, Saint Paul Mayor and Gubernatorial Candidate.

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Kuhl honed his skills in many areas including media relations and effective public policy writing as Communications Director for the Saint Paul Mayor and Statewide Candidates. Kuhl served as marketing director for the City of Saint Paul where he was responsible for the planning, promotion and execution of both large and small-scale events. In his role as policy liaison for United States Senator Norm Coleman, he was responsible for coordinating policy research and outreach on highly visible issues (transportation, energy, labor, budget, telecommunications, economic development, financial/banking, and appropriations) throughout Minnesota.

Prior to working at CKG, Kuhl managed and directed broad ranging public policy campaigns targeted at Federal, State and local officials. His unique experience working on communications, marketing and public policy issues allow him to blend the necessary skills to make any public policy campaign a success.

CASE STUDIES

Central Minnesota Transportation Alliance

The Central Minnesota Transportation Alliance (CMTA) is the transportation voice of Central Minnesota Business, advocating for a state of the art transportation system that positions St. Cloud and Central Minnesota as a focal point for future economic development and enhancing the area's quality of life. Since the spring of 2009, CKG, through founding partner Carl Kuhl, has served as Executive Director Consultant for the CMTA. CKG is responsible for overall organizational management communications and government relations as well as membership development for the organization.

Under CKG leadership, CMTA has been a strong advocate for MnDOT District 3 funding equity with the Minnesota Department of Transportation. This advocacy has resulted in three new interchange projects for Central Minnesota:

1. US Highway 10 & Benton County Road 2
2. Stearns County Road 120 & MN Highway 15
3. 33rd Street & MN Highway 15

Through tough economic times, CMTA has been able to grow their membership base while providing excellent value for members through quarterly events, newsletters and an enhanced digital media presence.

Reference: St. Cloud Area Chamber of Commerce President Teresa Bohnen

320-656-3804

tbohn@StCloudAreaChamber.com

See Appendix One: CMTA Newsletter

I-94 West Corridor Coalition

The I-94 West Corridor Coalition recently retained the Connolly Kuhl Group to provide organizational management including strategic planning and to lead the Coalition's communications, government relations and membership management efforts.

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Under CKG leadership, the Coalition has developed short and long term goals, designed a brand awareness campaign; including a kick-off event with business leaders, legislators and government officials and traditional and digital media components, and increased the Coalition's other legislative and executive branch advocacy efforts.

Longer term strategic planning for the I-94 West Coalition, developed by CKG, includes additional event planning and other activities focused on achieving specific legislative, administrative and funding goals.

Reference: St. Michael City Administrator Steve Bot

763-416-7931

sbot@ci.st-michael.mn.us

See Appendix Two: I-94 West Corridor Coalition Newsletter

Rochester Coalition

A coalition of the City of Rochester, Olmsted County, Rochester Area of Commerce and the Mayo Clinic faced a significant threat from the Dakota Minnesota & Eastern (DM&E) Railroad's desire to haul 1.5 mile coal trains through the city of Rochester, MN at speeds up to 50 mph, 34 times a day. The threat almost became a reality as DM&E closed in on a \$2.3 billion dollar loan guarantee from the Federal Railroad Administration. This would have resulted with new track in the Powder River Basin.

Connolly and Associates was retained in partnership with another firm to build a broad base of support from Winona to Wyoming, creating awareness regarding rail safety and loan guarantee impact. The Rochester Coalition managed a strategic, integrated public affairs campaign that included lobbying, public relations and grassroots that ultimately lead to the denial of the \$2.3 billion loan guarantee.

According to a March 1, 2007 Rochester Post Bulletin article the "*DM&E loan denial will become a text book study.*" Two key reasons cited for this outcome include:

- Strong public opinion against the project attracted political support
- Political opposition influenced the Washington bureaucracy

It's textbook. Business students will analyze the case for decades.

Reference: Olmsted County Commissioner Ken Brownbrown

507-288-7134

ken@co.olmsted.mn.us

PROPOSAL FOR SERVICES

Communications and Technology Services

Connolly Kuhl Group will create a close working relationship with the Highway 169 Corridor Coalition (Coalition) supplying leadership, management and guidance of the Coalition's communications needs. CGK will develop and implement a tactical communications plan designed to increase community awareness in the organization and its mission with coalition

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members, the public at large, elected officials and other state and local government officials.

Working with Bufflehead, CKG will manage the Coalition's website; ensuring the website is updated, at a minimum monthly, with any relevant news, related developments and the Coalition's activities (meeting agendas, minutes, presentations, etc.)

CKG will design, publish and distribute a quarterly newsletter, including graphics layout, detailing Coalition activities, accomplishments and other newsworthy items. CKG will also develop and maintain a membership mailing list. Working with the Coalition's Executive Committee, the newsletter's content will be reviewed and approved prior to its distribution.

CKG will establish Facebook and Twitter accounts and craft key messages and talking points to spread the Coalition's overall message and further advance the Coalition's goals. CKG will also maintain positive relationships with community partners, government officials, businesses and other organizations in an effort to advance the Coalition's agenda.

Administrative Services

Connolly Kuhl Group will facilitate location and logistics for all meetings (Executive Committee and overall Board meetings) including preparing and distributing agendas, meeting minutes, background materials and presentations. CKG will also ensure the physical space (table arrangement, technology set up, name tents, sign in sheet, etc.) match specific meeting needs. CKG will serve as meeting facilitator and will ensure meeting procedures, including recording minutes, establishing a quorum and recording votes, comply with Coalition bylaws.

Working with the Executive Committee, CKG will also develop meeting agenda items/ideas including guest presenters, relevant on-site visits or tours of locations/businesses, and other meeting opportunities that will help advance the Coalition's agenda. CKG will coordinate and facilitate all logistics related to these special meeting agenda items.

CKG will be responsible for bookkeeping and Coalition legal compliance including maintaining and distributing as appropriate monthly financial statements and annual invoices. CKG will oversee deposits, coordinate bill payments, and retain records for annual audit and regulatory filings; as well as any additional document filings.

Membership Services

Connolly Kuhl Group will work with the Coalition to grow and maintain its membership; managing each member's needs and expectations for the coalition. A strong emphasis will be placed on broadening membership with cities, counties, agencies, businesses and individuals. CKG will serve as the "welcoming committee" ensuring each new Coalition member receives all pertinent information necessary to fully engage in the Coalition's activities.

CKG will develop and maintain a database of members for more efficient and effective communication; potentially developing membership surveys to evaluate membership satisfaction, goals or to pursue other relevant fact-finding.

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CKG will also work closely with existing and new members to ensure the Coalition's communications strategy; its message, goals, and agenda are consistently applied across its membership.

Legislative Services

Connolly Kuhl Group will manage and coordinate logistics for the Coalition's annual Legislative breakfast. Working with the Executive Committee, CKG will identify and invite key legislative members of particular interest to Coalition goals.

CKG will also develop and distribute as appropriate materials outlining the legislative strategy developed by the Coalition's Board, as well as, other supporting materials as necessary to advance the Coalition's agenda.

PROJECT SCOPE

Based on the Coalition's estimate of 30 hours per week, the Connolly Kuhl Group proposes a monthly retainer of \$4,000. Our standard hourly rate for similar services is \$150 per hour; a retainer-based approach would result in a \$6,000 annual savings for the U.S. Highway 169 Corridor Coalition.

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Adam Axvig <adam@connollykuhlgroup.com>

Fwd: News from CMTA

Carl Kuhl <carl@connollykuhlgroup.com>

Fri, Jul 19, 2013 at 11:10 A

To: Adam Axvig <adam@connollykuhlgroup.com>, Amy Roberts <aroberts003@yahoo.com>

Begin forwarded message:

From: Central Minnesota Transportation Alliance <carl@connollykuhlgroup.com>**Subject:** News from CMTA**Date:** April 11, 2013 7:30:16 AM CDT**To:** carl@connollykuhlgroup.com**Reply-To:** carl@connollykuhlgroup.com

Central Minnesota
Transportation Alliance

Chairman Hornstein Visits St. Cloud**April 11, 2013**

Dear Carl,
Thank you for your continued
[membership in the CMTA.](#)

**Join Our Mailing List****Featured Article:****Chairman Hornstein, Rep. Dorholt meet with**

local business leaders and officials

Representative Frank Hornstein, Chairman of the Transportation Finance Committee, and Representative Zachary Dorholt, District 14B, met with business leaders and local officials from the St. Cloud area on Friday, April 5th to discuss the transportation needs of the St. Cloud area and Central Minnesota.

Hornstein called for a multi-modal focus for transportation, saying that all transportation is interconnected. Hornstein emphasized, "We get more bang for our buck in public investment and infrastructure than anything else we can spend our money on. There is nothing we can do to move our economy forward more than building roads, bridges, and transit. We have to be very clear and very united that we cannot continue to pit our modes of transportation against each other."

The Chairman also spoke in support of aviation, saying that regional airports could help alleviate the stress airfreight puts on MSP, and that aviation should be a statewide endeavor instead of being limited, for the most part, to the metropolitan area. He even went as far as to say that Rochester and St. Cloud could be important factors in statewide aviation.

When the conversation switched to the gas tax, Hornstein stated that his plan for Corridors of Commerce included a gas tax increase of 5 cents. Representative Dorholt pointed out that many people are supportive of transportation and transit improvements, but are not in favor of a gas tax increase, even though the gas tax is the main source of revenue for transportation funding. Governor Dayton announced on Monday however, that he would not support any increase in the gas tax.

Hornstein concluded by stating, "in mid March, the national society of civil engineers gave this country a D+ rating, and if we were in school, no one would be happy with that grade. We have to improve that rating if we are to compete nationally and globally. We have a modest bill that will raise the gas tax a little bit to fund our corridors of commerce, and transit that equates to one billion dollars of additional investment in our roads and bridges which includes money for central Minnesota. It is going to be a heavy lift. Support our transportation finance package. Physical infrastructure investments can't get any better than transportation investment."

About CMTA

CMTA is the transportation voice of Central Minnesota



by Mark Sommerhauser, St. Cloud Times
April 5th, 2013

A state House transportation-finance proposal set to be unveiled next week likely will include a gasoline-tax increase of between 5 and 7 1/2 cents per gallon, its sponsor said Friday.

Rep. Frank Hornstein, DFL-Minneapolis, who chairs a House transportation-finance panel, will be the proposal's sponsor. He said it will call for new tax revenue from the proposed gas-tax increase to be dedicated for a new state program through which grants would be awarded to municipalities for highway expansions on key arteries.

At least two Central Minnesota projects - an expansion of Interstate Highway 94 from Rogers to St. Michael and an expansion of Minnesota Highway 23 from Paynesville to Richmond - are among the projects that could compete for such grants, Hornstein said Friday afternoon. Hornstein's remarks came at a transportation roundtable discussion at the St. Cloud Metro Bus operations center.

A tax increase such as what Hornstein said he's likely to propose would generate about \$1 billion over 10 years, Hornstein said. He

Business, advocating for a state of the art transportation system that positions St. Cloud and Central Minnesota as a focal point for future economic development and enhances the areas quality of life.

Central Minnesota Transportation Alliance

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said the transportation finance proposal will be made public Monday and likely will face a committee vote Wednesday.

Hornstein said his proposal will include other provisions of interest for outstate Minnesota, including one permitting outstate county boards to impose local sales taxes for transportation by county board vote instead of by voter referendum, as is now required of outstate counties only.

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Adam Axvig <adam@connollykuhlgroup.com>

Fwd: News from the I-94 West Corridor Coalition

Carl Kuhl <carl@connollykuhlgroup.com>

Fri, Jul 19, 2013 at 11:09 A

To: Adam Axvig <adam@connollykuhlgroup.com>, Amy Roberts <aroberts003@yahoo.com>

Begin forwarded message:

From: I-94 West Corridor Coalition <carl@connollykuhlgroup.com>**Subject:** News from the I-94 West Corridor Coalition**Date:** May 29, 2013 3:35:26 PM CDT**To:** carl@connollykuhlgroup.com**Reply-To:** carl@connollykuhlgroup.com**May Newsletter****May 29, 2013****Dear Carl,**Thank you for your continued membership in the [I-94 Coalition](#).

Corridors of Commerce Clears Legislative Hurdle

The State Legislature passed the Transportation Bill which will fund more than \$4 billion in transportation investments, including \$300 million in trunk highway bonding for the newly created Corridors of Commerce program.

Included in the newly created Corridors of Commerce program

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**Status-quo
transportation bill
disappoints transit
advocates**

May 23, 2013
By Jessica Mador -
Minnesota Public Radio

ST. PAUL, Minn. - Minnesota
lawmakers this session
passed a "lights-on"

are specific eligibility and project criteria requirements for proposed projects. Interstate 94 appears to be able to meet the requirements laid out in the bill, though any project decisions will still be up to MNDOT Commissioner Zelle.

The bill is seen as status quo legislation, as it does not raise gas taxes, nor does it introduce significant sources of revenue for transportation projects. The \$10 wheelage tax option and a transportation sales tax option were included in the bill. The bill focuses mostly on road improvements, drawing praise from some legislators, but provided less money for other modes of transportation. House Transportation Finance Committee Chairman Frank Hornstein expressed displeasure with the overall lack of revenue support for further transportation improvements and added that legislators are eager to accomplish their local transportation projects, but are hesitant to raise the funding necessary. "We must do better than this. The needs are so clear."

The governor has said that he wants MnDOT to spend the coming summer and fall making the case with the public about why transportation investments are needed and how to fund them.

transportation bill, which does not include either a gas tax increase or a metro sales tax increase for transit. The bill passed without the new revenue many transportation advocates had hoped to gain for a long list of transit projects and road improvements.

Of the nearly two dozen mass transit projects the Metropolitan Council wants by 2030, just one received significant funding this session. Lawmakers allocated the \$37 million needed for the Southwest Corridor light rail line to move ahead. The money will fund the project through preliminary engineering, which is already underway. That means no delays for Southwest light rail transit, which will run between downtown Minneapolis and Eden Prairie.

But without an increase in the metro transit-dedicated sales tax, the LRT will need another \$81 million next session.

About the I-94 Coalition

The Minnesota I-94 West Corridor Coalition is a coalition of dedicated local governments, private businesses, local Chambers of Commerce and other stakeholders affected by the transportation challenges facing Minnesota.

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